facility in Balakot. The following day, a skirmish between the Indian and Pakistani air forces following retaliatory attempts by Pakistan led to the downing of an Indian aircraft and capture of its pilot, Abhinandan Varthaman. With tensions high, his swift release by Pakistan helped defuse the situation. [23] Despite India's strong focus on improving neighbourly relations between 2014 and 2019, Pakistan remained the outlier.

## Rebalance: China, the US, and the Indo–Pacific, 2014-2019

As prime minister, Modi also found himself immediately embroiled in relations with great powers. In September 2014, just months after his inauguration, Modi invited China's paramount leader Xi Jinping to his home state of Gujarat. While the optics were positive, China's People's Liberation Army (PLA) attempted an incursion around Chumar in Ladakh. While eventually defused, the timing of the PLA's actions was seen as a message to New Delhi and cast a pall upon the visit. Relations remained frosty over China's opposition to India's entry into the Nuclear Suppliers Group, its refusal to subject Pakistan-based terrorists to UN sanctions, and its advancement of the China-Pakistan Economic Corridor (CPEC) through Pakistan-occupied Kashmir. Furthermore, India boycotted the Belt and Road Forum in 2017, which was attended by many international delegates, including from Japan and the United States. Instead, India issued a statement arguing that infrastructure and connectivity financing should be transparent, financially and environmentally sustainable, beneficial to local communities, and respectful of recipient countries' sovereignty and territorial integrity. [24]

In June that year, Chinese and Indian forces entered into a standoff at Doklam, around the de facto border trijunction with Bhutan. China's road construction in territory disputed with Bhutan resulted in an intervention by Indian Army units. While China's media engaged in sabre-rattling and painted India as the aggressor, India argued that China had violated written agreements with Bhutan in 1988 and 1998 to maintain the status quo and a 2012 understanding with India to not unilaterally define tri-junctions with